

THE KING'S CRUSADE

A Gazetteer of the Long Road, from Duncarrow to the Braid

USING THIS GAZETTEER

Every entry below carries a stat line — how many people, who holds it, and what three years of occupation have done to it where that applies — followed by what the place is actually like and at least one reason for a party to go there. Populations for Elduvaine are given as they were before the fall, with the present figure after, because the difference is the campaign.

Distances matter in this campaign more than in most, because the march is half of it. The table gives the legs the coalition actually travels. Times assume an army; a party of six moving alone and pushing hard does most of these in two thirds of the time, and the Willing Road does whatever the Willing Road does.

Leg	Time	Notes
Duncarrow to Ellendrake	6 days	Metalled road the whole way, the only one Harrowmark has. Xavier paid for it and mentions this.
Ellendrake to Caerwyn, by sea	3 weeks	With fair weather, which the coalition did not get. Storms scatter fleets onto Calanthe.
Duncarrow to Ashgate Ford	12 days	Good country, then hill country, then Baron Vell.
Ashgate Ford to the Cold Stair	5 days	Climbing the whole way. The last day is the pass itself.
The Cold Stair to Caerwyn	3 weeks	Down the far side and along the coast. Longer than the sea road and considerably less wet.
Caerwyn to Vindana	9 days	Four, on the days the Willing Road agrees to it. Nobody can arrange those days.
Vindana to Caer Ysolde	11 days	Upriver along the Braid. The last three days are inside Vale's reach and everybody knows it.
Caerwyn to Caer Ysolde, direct	16 days	Through the Orchard Marches. Beautiful, and in year three, wrong.

HARROWMARK

Hill country, thin soil, and stone that will take a wall better than it will take a plough. Harrowmark occupies a wedge of high ground between two ranges and has spent nine hundred years being a place nobody else particularly wanted, which is the entire secret of its survival and most of its personality. The land does nothing. The people do everything, unhurriedly, and are quietly certain this makes them the only serious kingdom on the continent.

It is wyvern country. It has always been wyvern country. Every hold above the eight-hundred-foot line keeps a watch, every watch keeps a pike-rack, and every year some number of people do not come back down. Harrowmark has arranged its architecture, its livestock, its calendar and a good deal of its humour around this, and considers the arrangement normal.

A visitor's first impression is grey — grey stone, grey weather, grey wool — and the second impression, arriving about four days later, is that everything in it is built extremely well. Nothing here is decorative. Everything here is still standing.

DUNCARROW

Population 14,000 · Seat of Xavier III · The muster ground of the crusade

The capital sits on a spur above the Draymere with the Marchhold at its head, and it is less a city than a fortress that acquired a town by accident and never quite decided what to do about it. Three concentric walls, all of them still garrisoned, all of them raised at different centuries and none of them demolished, so the streets run in rings and a stranger walking to the keep will pass the same bakery twice and begin to suspect the city of doing it on purpose.

The Long Stair climbs from the river gate to the Marchhold in four hundred and ten steps, and by ancient custom a king of Harrowmark walks it rather than rides. Xavier has walked it three times a week for eleven years and can tell you what each landing smells like. Below it, the mustering fields have held eight thousand people since the Call and now smell of exactly that.

The Ninefold House of Duncarrow is the largest Concord chapter in the kingdom and the place the Call was read from, in Ninefold Cant, on a wet morning to a crowd that mostly could not understand a word of it and understood the whole thing perfectly.

Hook. Module One happens here. Beyond that: the Marchhold's lower vaults hold two centuries of Harrowmark's correspondence with Elduvaine, unread, and somebody in the Archive at Caer Ysolde wrote back.

GREYWATCH

Population 900 · The high wyvern-watch · Huntmaster Brenna Vane

Eleven hundred feet up, four days from Duncarrow, and the reason the eastern valleys have livestock. Greywatch exists to kill wyverns, has existed to kill wyverns for nine centuries, and is very good at it in the way that only an institution with an unbroken casualty list can be. Dwarves take the pikes, because a pike-wall needs people who will not move. Orcs take the ropes, because the ropes go over the edge. Nobody at Greywatch regards either of those facts as being about dwarves or orcs; they are about pikes and ropes.

The hold itself is one long hall dug back into the cliff with a stone yard in front of it, and the yard is where the hunt assembles, the dead are laid out, and the drinking happens, in that order and often on the same night. There is a wall inside the hall with names on it. It is not a memorial. It is a roster, and the dead are simply not crossed off.

Hook. Brenna Vane will take anyone up who asks and is the campaign's best source of Harrowmark texture, camp levity, and blunt opinion. The wyvern-riders who go to Vindana with the army are hers, and she has views about lending them.

ELLENDRAKE

Population 6,000 · Harrowmark's only true port · The fleet sails from here

A working harbour town on a coast that does not want one, kept open by a mole three centuries old and a dredging levy everyone complains about and everyone pays. Ellendrake has never been beautiful and has stopped attempting it. What it has is deep water, a tide that behaves, and more rope, tar, salt fish and profane opinion per acre than anywhere else in the kingdom.

Since the Call it has been the most crowded place in Harrowmark. Ninety-one hulls of wildly varying quality, requisitioned from four owners who are still arguing about compensation, and an Auberitz harbourmaster who arrived uninvited, took one look, and began reorganising the entire anchorage with the calm of a woman who has done this before.

Hook. Module 2A sails from here. Before that: something in the requisitioned tonnage is not seaworthy, the owner knows, and the manifest says otherwise.

STANNOCK

Population 1,600 · Dwarf crag hold · The armouries

Cut back into the western crags and reached by a road that switches back on itself eleven times, Stannock makes mail, pike-heads, and the particular long-hafted wyvern spear that no other kingdom has any use for. It has been making them for six hundred years, the pattern has changed twice, and both changes are still discussed.

The crusade emptied the place. Stannock worked through two winters to arm the muster and then sent four hundred of its own with the result, which is a quarter of everyone it had. The forges are banked, the halls are quiet, and the people left are mostly over ninety or under twenty and all of them are waiting.

Hook. The armourers kept the pattern-book. Anything the party needs made to Harrowmark standard can be made here — slowly, correctly, and with a great deal of comment about how it will be misused.

CORRIEHOLT

Population 1,800 · Orc high country · Horses, and the hill-fighting tradition

The high pasture north of Greywatch, held by orc families who have grazed it for as long as Harrowmark has had records and rather longer than Harrowmark has had a king. Corrieholt breeds the only horses in the kingdom worth the

name — small, ugly, appallingly durable animals that will go up a slope no sensible mount would look at — and it supplies the light horse that the coalition has been quietly grateful for at every river crossing since the landing.

It also supplies a fighting tradition: fast, dispersed, and built entirely around not being where the enemy expected. Auberitz officers find it undisciplined. Auberitz officers have also stopped saying so out loud since the second week of the march.

Hook. A Corrieholt rider in the coalition has family in the Sixth Free Legion. This is true, it is known, and nobody in the column has made anything of it, which is exactly the campaign's position on the matter.

FENMARROW

Population 3,100 across a dozen villages · Thin farm country · Where the levy comes from

The low ground south of Duncarrow, and the only part of Harrowmark that grows enough of anything to matter. It is not good land. It is worked land, in narrow strips, by families who have improved it inch by inch for three centuries and will tell you the history of a particular hedge if you give them any opening at all.

Most of the crusade's infantry is from here. Not the knights and not the professionals — the eight thousand. They answered a summons read in a language they did not speak, promising a place in a country they could not find on a map, and they are marching to it, and the DM should remember that every time the coalition is discussed as a political object.

Hook. Somebody's mother in Fenmarrow gave the party a letter for her son in the column. He is in the lost column on the other road. This costs nothing to set up in Module One and pays for the rest of the campaign.

KETTLEBURN

Population 400 · A village with a scar · Two days off the Duncarrow road

Eleven years ago a wyvern nested above Kettleburn and stayed for a season before Greywatch could bring it down, and the village has been the standing Harrowmark illustration of what that costs ever since. Half the houses were rebuilt. The rebuilt half is better than the original. The people are neither traumatised nor especially interested in discussing it, and a visitor who tries for pathos will be given a very dry account of roof repairs.

Hook. The best low-stakes scene in Harrowmark for establishing what these people are like before the party leaves. They are not brave. They are unimpressed, and it is not the same thing.

ENCOUNTERS IN HARROWMARK

Roll d12 once per day of travel, or when the pace wants breaking. Harrowmark is a settled kingdom in the middle of a muster: most of what a party meets is people.

d12	Encounter
1	A wyvern (SRD, CR 6), hunting, and not remotely interested in a fair fight. It will take a pack animal and leave if allowed to.
2–3	A levy company of forty walking to Duncarrow, badly, singing. Their sergeant is nineteen and terrified and hiding it well.
4	Four bandits (SRD, CR 1/8) who used to be a levy company and thought better of it. They will surrender to anyone competent.
5	A Concord priest of Voran walking the other way, who will feed anybody and asks nothing except news, which she then writes down.
6	A Greywatch rope-team, off duty, three days into an argument about a knot. They will absolutely make it the party's problem.
7	An Auberitz supply column, stuck. A wheel, a ford, a permit, or all three.
8	Weather. Harrowmark weather, which means a full day lost and everyone soaked to the bone and unsurprised.
9	A Norvatch factor riding to Duncarrow, ahead of the market, ledger already open.
10	A pack of six wolves (SRD, CR 1/4) working the road because the flocks moved with the muster.
11	A hill giant (SRD, CR 5) down out of the crags in a bad year, more hungry than hostile, and negotiable if anyone thinks to try.
12	Riders of the Tenth Work, courteous, well-supplied, and extremely interested in where the party is going and why.

THE SEA ROAD

Three weeks of open water from Ellendrake to the Elduvish coast, in ninety-one hulls of which perhaps sixty were built for it. The sea road is faster, cheaper, and carries the siege train, which is the argument that won the council. It is also the road on which a storm can undo in one night what four months of organising achieved, and everybody who voted for it knew that too.

CALANTHE

Population 2,200 · An independent island · Warden Ivor Thane, self-styled

A hook of rock and gorse eleven miles long, lying inconveniently across the shipping lane, answering to no crown and never having been worth the cost of taking. Calanthe has one harbour, four hundred years of wrecking, and a population that has grown entirely comfortable with the distinction between salvage and theft being a matter of where you are standing.

Ivor Thane holds it from a hall above the harbour and calls himself Warden, which is a title Calanthe invented for him and Calanthe can uninvent. He is not a pirate — he is careful about this — he is a man who charges for rescue, keeps what washes up, and has never once been proved to have moved a light. The distinction has kept him alive for nineteen years and will not survive contact with a coalition that needs its supplies back.

Hook. Module 2A. Beyond it: Thane's cellar holds four hundred years of salvaged cargo manifests, and three of them are Elduvish, and one of them is from a ship that sailed after the wards opened.

THE OSSARY SHOALS

A wrecking coast · Nine miles of it · No population, by design

The shoals run north from Calanthe under six feet of water at the low tide and none at all at the high, and they are the reason Calanthe eats. Local pilots can take a hull through at a walking pace. Local pilots charge accordingly, and the price is a matter of what the cargo is, which they will establish first.

At the low spring tide the wrecks stand out of the water — forty or fifty of them across four centuries, masts and ribs and one intact stern-castle sitting upright in the sand with weed in its windows. Calanthe children play in it. Nobody on the island finds this remarkable and every visitor does.

ENCOUNTERS AT SEA

d10	Encounter
1–2	Weather, worsening. A day of it, and a real chance of separation from the fleet.
3	A hull in trouble — sprung seams, and forty people on deck doing arithmetic about the boats.
4	Calanthe pilots, alongside, cheerful, and offering a service the party did not ask for at a price they will not like.
5	A Norvatch merchantman on her lawful business, who will trade news and refuses passengers.
6	Four merrow (SRD, CR 2) working the fleet's wake for anything that goes overboard, including people.
7	A becalming. Three days, no wind, eight thousand soldiers on ninety-one boats, and tempers.
8	A giant octopus (SRD, CR 1) on a small boat, which is far worse than it sounds if the small boat is yours.
9	Wreckage from the other road, which is impossible, and is not.
10	A young kraken's wake — no encounter, just a mile of flat water and every sailor aboard gone very quiet.

THE MOUNTAIN ROAD

Longer, drier, and it cannot carry the siege engines, which is why it carries everything else. The mountain road climbs from Harrowmark's eastern hills through the Cold Stair and comes down the far side into three weeks of coastal going. Its virtue is that no storm can scatter it. Its cost is Baron Vell, the pass itself, and the fact that everything on it walks.

ASHGATE FORD

Population 700 · Baron Vell's toll-keep · The last easy crossing

The river is wide, shallow, fast and cold, and there has been a toll on it since somebody first noticed that the alternative is eleven days upstream. The keep is squat, competently sited, and older than the barony it now supports; the village below it exists to feed the keep and to sell rope, boots and hot food to people who have just discovered how cold the water is.

Vell's toll is legal. That is the difficulty with Vell. He holds the ford by a charter four generations old, the charter says what he may charge, and what he has done is notice that the charter never contemplated eight thousand people and a war.

Hook. Module 2B. Also: the charter is in the keep, it is genuine, and there is a clause in it that Vell has never read because it is on the back.

KIR HALLOWAY

Population 1,100 · A mountain trade town · Nobody's, officially

Two days above Ashgate, wedged into a valley that gets four hours of direct sun in winter, and existing because two roads meet there and both of them are bad. Kir Holloway is dwarves, humans, and a startling number of tieflings whose families came up from Norvatch three generations back and stayed for the trade. It has one inn with eleven beds, four warehouses, and a market that operates on the third day of every week regardless of weather, war, or whether anybody has come.

It is also the last place on the mountain road where a party can buy anything at all. The next four hundred miles are the pass, and then Elduvaine, and Elduvaine has permits.

Hook. A Norvatch house factor keeps a permanent office here and has done for sixty years. She knows what has been going up the road and, more usefully, what has been coming down it out of Elduvaine.

THE COLD STAIR

The pass · 5,100 feet · Open perhaps five months a year

A stair in name and nearly in fact: eleven miles of switchbacks cut into the eastern face, wide enough for two carts abreast where somebody widened it and wide enough for one where nobody did. The wind comes across it rather than along it. There is no water for the middle four miles, no shelter for the last three, and a set of stone refuge huts, most of them roofless, that a party will be extremely glad of at least once.

At the summit there is a cairn. Travellers add a stone. It has been there long enough to be twenty feet across and it is the only thing anyone has ever built on the Cold Stair that the mountain has not taken back.

Hook. Somebody has been robbing the refuge huts of their roofing timber, which is a small crime and, at five thousand feet in the wrong month, a lethal one.

THE OLD WORKINGS

Abandoned mines above Ashgate · Kobold-held · Older than the barony

Silver, four hundred years ago, and not enough of it. The workings run further into the hill than any surviving map shows and have been held for two generations by a kobold warren that arrived when the last human left and has been improving the place ever since — which is to say, trapping it comprehensively, signposting every trap in Draconic, and being extremely reasonable with anyone who reads Draconic.

Hook. They want three things: to be left alone, a written guarantee of it, and somebody to do something about what is in the flooded lower gallery. They will pay for the third in silver they have no use for.

BARROWFELL

An upland of graves · No living population · Two days off the road

Four hundred barrows across nine miles of moor, raised by people nobody can now name, on a schedule nobody can reconstruct. Harrowmark's scholars think they predate the kingdom by a wide margin. Harrowmark's shepherds think they should be left alone, and have been proved right on eleven recorded occasions.

DM Only: Barrowfell is the campaign's one piece of deliberate deep background and it has nothing whatever to do with Vale, Elduvaine, or the war. That is the point. A setting where every ruin is plot is a setting with no history in it. Put something genuinely old and genuinely unrelated down here, let the party spend an optional session on it, and never connect it to anything.

ENCOUNTERS ON THE MOUNTAIN ROAD

d12	Encounter
1	Weather at altitude, which is a hazard rather than an encounter: exhaustion, lost days, and a real question about the refuge huts.
2–3	A goat-track. It is shorter. It is also not what it looks like, and the party will be committed before they know.
4	Six kobolds (SRD, CR 1/8) on a scouting loop, who would much rather talk and have prepared a speech.
5	An ogre (SRD, CR 2) who has claimed a refuge hut and considers it his, which under the local rules of the road it now sort of is.
6	A stranded Auberitz wagon, its crew, and a mathematical certainty that it cannot be got over the pass.
7	Two griffons (SRD, CR 2) nesting above the switchbacks, hunting the pack animals.
8	Pilgrims of the Tenth Work walking to Elduvaine unarmed, having refused an escort, three days from dying of it.
9	A rockfall across the road. Four hours to clear, or a day to go around, and somebody is watching to see which.

d12	Encounter
10	A troll (SRD, CR 5) under a bridge, doing the traditional thing, and genuinely open to the traditional solutions.
11	Cold. Simple, unglamorous cold — a night that costs the party a level of exhaustion apiece unless somebody plans.
12	The lost column's first courier, coming the wrong way, with news he does not want to be carrying.

ELDUVAINE: THE VAUNT

The coastal province, and the first Elduvaine anyone in this campaign sees. The Vaunt is low, green, wet in the good way, and threaded with tidal creeks that the halfling parishes have been navigating in flat-bottomed boats since before there were roads to prefer. It holds the kingdom's great port, its landing beaches, and about a fifth of its people.

It is also where the occupation is heaviest, because it is where the goods leave from. A party arriving in the Vaunt is arriving in the most administered part of Elduvaine: permits, checkpoints, published levies, and a Norvatch counting-house three streets back from every quay.

VINDANA

Population 28,000, now perhaps 19,000 · The great port · Held by Marshal Ossian Drell

Elduvaine's window on the world, and the second city of the kingdom by every measure except the one that matters, which is that Caer Ysolde has the Archive. Vindana is built on a rise above a deep-water harbour, walled twice, and the walls are the reason the campaign spends two whole modules here. The inner wall is Standing Light stone: it held daylight, and for six centuries the city glowed faintly from its own defences on any clear night. It does not now.

The harbour front is warehouses, rope-walks, and the smell of a working port. Behind it the city climbs in terraces to the Ward Gate and the garrison quarter, and behind that is the undercity — a drain and cistern system older than the walls above it, which the garrison stopped patrolling two years ago because something else moved in.

Under the occupation Vindana has become the machine that empties Elduvaine. Everything that leaves the kingdom leaves through here, weighed, docketed, and carried in Norvatch bottoms under a standing contract. The people who load it are Elduvish and are paid.

Hook. Modules 6, 7 and 8. Before and around them: the undercity, the counting-house, and Ottoline Vahn filing objections from what she insists on calling her chambers.

CAERWYN

Population 1,600 · The landing town · Occupation grip: thin

A small coastal town of grey-gold stone and slate, eleven miles of orchard behind it, and a hedge at the top of the town that has sprites in it and always has. Caerwyn is far enough from both Vindana and the capital that the occupation posted a checkpoint, a clerk and eight guards and

considered the matter closed, which is why the coalition chose it.

It is the first wonder the party gets and it should be run as one. The light-stone in the doorsteps still holds a little of the afternoon. The baker's ovens have not gone out in two hundred years and the whole street smells of it at four in the morning. This is a place worth saving, and the module says so by showing rather than arguing.

Hook. Module Three. Wyn Alder clerks the checkpoint and is the campaign's first honest look at what an ordinary complicit person is actually like.

THE DEAD MILE

A mile of road · Nothing lives on it · Between Caerwyn and the interior

A stretch of the coast road where the draining was done early, thoroughly, and without any attempt at subtlety, and where the land has simply stopped. Not blasted — that would be easier to look at. The hedges are there. The grass is there. None of it is doing anything: no insects, no birds, no smell, and a silence that a party notices about four hundred yards in and cannot stop noticing afterwards.

Wagons go through it at a trot. Nobody camps in it. There is no monster in the Dead Mile and there is nothing to fight, which is exactly why it is the most frightening place in the first half of the campaign.

MORGARTH

Population 2,900, now 800 · A fishing town, emptied · Two days south of Vindana

The Vaunt's second port, and the place the occupation made an example of in the first year — not by massacre, which would have been off-pattern, but by levy. Morgarth's boats were requisitioned, its catch was docketed, and its people were charged for the privilege of the arrangement until two thirds of them walked inland. It was entirely lawful. Every step of it is in the register.

What remains is eight hundred people in a town built for three thousand, working the boats that were left, and a harbourmaster who has kept every single piece of paper.

Hook. Those papers are the second-best account of the occupation's arithmetic in Elduvaine, after Norvatch's. Unlike Norvatch's, they are free, and the harbourmaster has been waiting three years for somebody to ask.

ENCOUNTERS IN THE VAUNT

d12	Encounter
1–2	A checkpoint. Permits, a bored clerk, four guards, and the entire scene turning on whether anyone in the party can be boring convincingly.
3	A Legion patrol of six, professional, uninterested, and willing to be talked past.
4	A carter with a docketed load and a very careful account of exactly how legal it all is.
5	A halfling family on a flat-bottomed boat who will move the party through the creeks for nothing and talk the entire way.

d12	Encounter
6	Four sprites (SRD, CR 1/4) in a hedge, invisible, keeping up a running commentary.
7	A stretch of road that is longer than it was. No encounter. Just the distance, quietly wrong.
8	Three Norvatch carters, on schedule, who will not stop and will answer questions shouted alongside.
9	Two ghouls (SRD, CR 1) in a drained orchard — the draining kills things, and not everything that dies in the Vaunt stays down.
10	A Tenth Work chapter house going up on ground that had an Observance on it last year.
11	An Unbound Clerk, hiding, half-starved, carrying four pages he will die rather than hand over.
12	A drained dryad — see the Bestiary — no longer able to leave a wood that no longer exists.

ELDUVAINE: THE BRAID

Three rivers come down out of three different countries and meet in one valley, and everything Elduvaine is came out of that fact. The Braid is the heartland: the capital, the Archive, the oldest parishes, the seat of the house, and the densest concentration of resident magic anywhere in the world.

It is also where Vale is, which means the last third of the campaign happens here and the party will spend it being extremely careful.

CAER YSOLDE

Population 41,000, now perhaps 30,000 · The capital · Held by Maedoc Vale in person

The city stands on and between the three rivers, on nine islands and both banks, connected by more bridges than anyone has successfully counted — the standing figure is sixty-one and it has been sixty-one for two hundred years regardless of how many have been built since. It is the most beautiful city in the world and it is not close, and every visiting ambassador for six centuries has said so in writing, usually while complaining about the damp.

Caer Ysolde is built of light-stone almost entirely. On a clear night before the fall the whole city glowed the colour of late afternoon, from the ground up, bright enough to read by on the bridges and dim enough to see stars through. That is what it was famous for. That is what a Harrowmark levyman has heard about since he was a child.

It is dark now. Not lightless — the occupation burns lamps like anybody else — but the stone is out, and it went out over about fourteen months, quarter by quarter, in a way the people who live there could watch happening.

Hook. Module Eleven, and the whole campaign points here. Maelis Ysolde is held in her own apartments in the Ysolde Keep on the middle island.

THE YSOLDE ARCHIVE

The largest collection of magical knowledge in the world · Vale's, now

Nine floors above ground and an unstated number below, occupying most of the middle island, and governed for four hundred and eighty years by the single decision that makes this campaign possible: access by rule, not by power. A farmer with a legitimate question could read what the rule allowed a farmer to read. A monarch could not read past what the rule allowed a monarch. Neither could the Keeper.

The reading rooms are still open. That is the detail that unsettles people most. Vale has kept the Archive functioning — clerks at the desks, requests filed, materials fetched — because he is not a vandal and because a working Archive is more use to him than a looted one. Elduvish scholars still come. Some of them still work there. They are paid.

DM Only: what is in the deepest vaults has not been decided and must not be invented. The sourcebook states Vale's motive — he was refused, by rule, and he is spending a kingdom to finish reading — and it deliberately does not state his destination. Describe the doors. Describe the rule. Do not describe what is behind them. If the party gets that far, the campaign is more interesting for the DM answering it at their own table than for this book answering it here.

DM Only: one dragon older than the current wards sleeps somewhere near or under the Archive and answers to neither Vale nor the party. This is a single deep-vault exception, it is not a general rule about Elduvish dragons, and it does not answer the question above. It sleeps until the campaign needs it to stop.

SENNOCH HALL

A great house of the Braid · Two days downriver of the capital · A gilded prison

A country seat of the house, walled, moated in the ornamental sense, and entirely unsuited to being a place of detention — which is exactly why the occupation chose it. Ninian Ysolde has been held here for three years in considerable comfort, with a library, a garden, a staff who are not permitted to leave, and a garrison that is embarrassed about the whole arrangement.

Hook. Module Four. The garrison commander here has been correct, courteous and humane for three years and would very much like somebody to notice that before this ends badly for him.

LISSWATER

Population 2,100 · A river parish · Halfling country, and the kingdom's manners

Where the middle river runs slow for nine miles, there are eleven villages that consider themselves one place, and Lisswater is the name of all of them and none of them. It is halfling country: locks, weirs, eel traps, orchards on the levee, and the single best food in Elduvaine by a margin that the rest of the kingdom concedes without argument.

The Listening Water is at its strongest along this stretch, and Lisswater has spent nine hundred years developing an etiquette around it so thorough that outsiders find it incomprehensible. You do not speak at the water's edge

about anything you would not repeat. You do not stand at the edge when angry. Children are taught the rule before they are taught to swim, and adults who break it are not scolded but quietly and permanently regarded as unserious.

Hook. The whole of the Four Voices technique works best here. So does the miller who has been miscounting the levy for two years and would like to stop being the only person doing it.

THE THREEFOLD STAIR

Where the rivers meet · A mile below the capital · An engineering work and a shrine

The three rivers do not simply join. They arrive at different heights, and nine centuries ago somebody built the Stair to marry them: three broad flights of worked channel, dropping the two higher rivers to the level of the third across about half a mile, in a controlled and continuous roar that can be heard from the city walls on a still night.

It is the largest single piece of Standing Light work in Elduvaine, and at night the falling water used to carry the glow down with it. Every Observance in the Braid ends at the Stair. It is not holy. It is simply the place everybody goes.

ENCOUNTERS IN THE BRAID

d12	Encounter
1	A Legion officer of rank, escorted, on the road with a clear purpose and an interest in who else is.
2–3	A permit inspection at a bridgehead — and there are sixty-one bridges, so this is the Braid's weather.
4	An Observance in progress at a wayside. Twenty people, no priest, and a party that interrupts will be forgiven and remembered.
5	Resistance: a signal chalked on a lock gate, meaning something the party could learn to read.
6	A collaborator clerk who wants, desperately and dangerously, to give somebody a document.
7	Four Legion scouts (Ashgate Scout block) shadowing the party for a full day before deciding anything.
8	A stretch of Willing Road that shortens dramatically and inexplicably, in the party's favour, for no reason anyone will ever establish.
9	A will-o'-wisp (SRD, CR 2) over the flooded lower parishes, which the locals have a name for and do not fear correctly.
10	An Unbound Clerk's dead drop, still stocked, its owner three weeks gone.
11	The Tenth Work, consecrating ground, entirely lawfully, while the parish stands and watches.
12	One of Vale's own — a battle-mage on the road, alone, unhurried, and not looking for a fight but entirely equal to one.

ELDUVAINE: THE ORCHARD MARCHES

The upland between the Braid and the northern hills, and the institution that made the elves of Elduvaine what they are. A Kept Season wood holds the season it was planted in, forever, and the Marches are four hundred years of people planting deliberately: a spring wood here, a high-summer wood there, an autumn stand kept for the timber it gives in that state, laid out across ninety miles like an argument nobody has finished.

Walking the Marches in the old days meant crossing from full blossom into deep autumn in the space of a hedge, four times before lunch, and the roads were laid out to make the transitions land well. It was the single most-visited thing in Elduvaine and the kingdom made a great deal of money from people who wanted to see it.

BRYN AELING

The oldest orchard · Planted four days into spring, seven hundred years ago · Now nine weeks into a winter

The first Kept Season planting and the greatest of them, forty acres of birch and apple that has been four days into spring since before Harrowmark had a king. Generations of Elduvish came here to be married under it, because a wood four days into spring is four days into spring on the morning of your wedding regardless of what the calendar says, and that was the whole point.

It is nine weeks into a winter it was never sown in, and has been for most of a year. The trees are dying — not dead, dying, slowly and in the wrong order — and an ecology has moved in behind the change: winter wolves along the edges, and a troll in the orchard-keeper's cottage, and the dryad who has been the spirit of this wood for three centuries and is now the spirit of a winter one and cannot leave.

Hook. Module Five's Held Winter. The single most legible image of the draining in the campaign, and the one scene where a party can simply sit down and talk to the grief.

NANTCORROW

Population 1,900 · An orchard town · The Season-keepers' seat

Where the Marches are administered from, insofar as they are administered at all: a town of long low halls and drying-lofts, given over almost entirely to fruit, timber, and the extremely serious business of deciding where the next wood goes and in which week it should be sown. A planting decision at Nantcorrow is a four-hundred-year decision and is argued like one.

The Season-keepers are still here. They have not been arrested, because arresting them would stop the orchards producing, and the occupation would like the orchards to keep producing. They have therefore spent three years administering an institution on behalf of a man who is killing it, which is a position several of them can no longer live with.

Hook. The Keepers know exactly which woods have turned and in what order. That map is the best measurement

of the draining that exists outside Norvatch's ledgers, and it is not for sale, and they will give it to the right people.

ELDUVAINE: THE STANDING MARCHES

Hill country west of the Braid, and the source of the other thing Elduvaine is famous for. Worked stone from these quarries holds light poured into it — an afternoon's sun, a lamp, a spell — and gives it back for hours or days depending on the cut. The whole of *Caer Ysolde* is built of it, and so is every doorstep in *Caerwyn*, and so is the inner wall of *Vindana*.

CAIRN ITHEL

Population 3,400 • The light-stone quarries • Gnome country

Six working quarries and a town wedged between them, gnome-run for six hundred years, with a mason's guild whose apprenticeship is eleven years and whose masters can look at a face of rock and tell you how long a block cut from it will hold an evening. The cut is everything. The same stone cut two ways holds light for a day or for a week, and the difference is a craft secret that has never been written down.

The occupation has the quarries working double. What it is producing is not building stone.

DM Only: the party can work out what the quarries are producing for, and it is one of the campaign's better mid-game discoveries: light-stone cut to hold, then drained, is the most efficient way anyone has found to move Elduvaine's resident magic in a cart. Cairn Ithel is not being worked. It is being packaged.

Hook. A master mason at Cairn Ithel has been deliberately cutting badly for two years — stone that holds for an hour instead of a week — and has cost the occupation a great deal, and knows exactly how long she has.

YSGARON

Population 1,200 • A mason town • Where the Standing Light was learned

Smaller, older, and higher than Cairn Ithel, and the place the craft was worked out, six centuries ago, by people whose names are on a wall in the guild hall. Ysgaron does the fine work: the cut faces, the inlays, the lamps that are not lamps. Most of what makes *Caer Ysolde* beautiful was made here by about nine hundred people over six hundred years.

Hook. The guild hall's wall of names is also, unintentionally, a four-hundred-year technical record. Anyone who can read it can work out how the cut is done. Vale has not been here yet.

THE WILLING ROAD

It runs from the coast at *Caerwyn* to the capital and on north to the Marches, marked at intervals by waystones nobody can date, and it shortens for travellers who mean well. That is all four hundred years of scholarship has established, and it is not for want of effort — the Archive

holds an entire shelf of failed attempts, most of them by people who were certain they had it.

The waystones are unremarkable: waist-high, weathered, unlettered, and set at intervals that do not correspond to any unit anybody uses. There are three hundred and eleven of them. Nobody put them there. This is not a legend or an evasion; the Archive has looked, exhaustively, and there is no record of the road being built, no record of anyone claiming to have built it, and no record of a time before it.

DM Only: see *Travelling the Willing Road* in the sourcebook. The essential rule bears repeating because it is the one thing in this setting that a well-meaning DM will ruin by being helpful: do not decide what it measures. Not even privately. The road is the only genuine mystery in a campaign whose villain, war and stakes are all fully explained, and it is load-bearing for exactly that reason.

THE COALITION REALMS, IN BRIEF

None of these are on the party's road, and all three are on the party's political map. What follows is what a well-briefed officer of the crusade would be able to tell you over dinner.

THE KINGDOM OF OKSITAN

River and horse country, four hundred miles of it, and every great house in it holds a ford. Humans in the main, with an old landed nobility that is substantially dragonborn — the houses of *Vashkar*, *Ourrez*, *Sarrelan* and *Kaldiss* between them hold every significant crossing on the *Vaskren* and have done since before the records begin. Oksitan is rich, well-mounted, and organised entirely around the control of movement.

Its capital is *Aurignan*, on the *Vaskren*, which is less a city than a very large bridge with a city attached to both ends of it. Its king is *Raimon V*, who is seventy-one and has gone in person. Its army takes the road the party does not.

THE GRAND DUCHY OF AUBERITZ

The duchy that builds things. Humans, gnomes and halflings, mercantile and engineering rather than martial, wealthy in a quiet way that Oksitan finds vulgar and *Harrowmark* does not notice. Auberitz has no significant cavalry tradition, no chivalric literature to speak of, and the best siege train in the world — gnome-designed, halfling-quartermastered, and moved by people who have thought harder about roads than about glory.

Its capital shares the duchy's name. Its arsenal is at *Krenholt*, which is where the engines that will open *Vindana* were built, over nine months, to a specification that assumed the walls would be worse than they are.

DM Only: what Auberitz actually wants, beyond the Promise, has not been decided and is not invented here. Its role, its people, its engineers and its politics-of-logistics are all canon and all usable. Run its officers by role until the question is settled: they are competent, unimpressed by everyone else's war, and privately convinced this is a supply problem being mishandled by people who enjoy shouting.

THE KINGDOM OF NORVATCH

Guild-law country: dwarves and tieflings, humans throughout, and an entire realm whose standing in the world rests on the proposition that a Norvatch contract is honoured to the letter no matter what the letter turns out to have meant. It did not take the Call. It deals with either side. It answers to nobody, and it will keep a bargain it has made.

Its great counting-city is Torvhal, where the Writ House sits — a court that has never in two centuries ruled on whether an agreement was fair, only on what it said. Norvatch does not want Elduvaine. Norvatch wants to remain the market for what leaves it, guaranteed in writing by whoever holds the place when the war ends, and it has held exactly that arrangement with the occupation for three years.

Hook. House Kell's ledgers are the campaign's clock. Doria Kell will sell them. Her price is in Module Ten and it is worse than money.

~

“There are sixty-one bridges in Caer Ysolde. There have been sixty-one bridges in Caer Ysolde for two hundred years. We have built nine in that time and lost none, and it is still sixty-one, and we would all be grateful if you did not raise it again.”

— the Bridgewarden of Caer Ysolde, to a visiting Auberitz surveyor